

Unit Y311: The Origins and Growth of the British Empire 1558–1783

This theme focuses on the changing nature of the emerging British Empire over this period. Learners should understand the factors which encouraged and discouraged change during this period. Learners should study developments across the whole of the Empire, including the Americas (North America and the Caribbean), India and the wider 'Indies', ports and naval bases such as Gibraltar, Africa and the Pacific. Study should not be limited to areas of direct political control; learners should have an appreciation of how spheres of influence and formal and informal

economic, social and political ties and scientific and geographical exploration contributed to imperial development. The strands identified below are not to be studied in isolation to each other.

Learners are not expected to demonstrate a detailed understanding of the specification content, except for the named in-depth studies, but are expected to know the main developments and turning points relevant to the theme.

Theme: The Origins and Growth of the British Empire 1558–1783	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
Drivers of imperial expansion	Attitude and contribution of the Crown, Court and Parliament to overseas expansion; the importance of key individuals including Drake, Rayleigh, Clive; imperial priorities e.g. North West and North East Passage, Trade, Spices, The West Indies; contribution of domestic developments to empire including religious developments, Civil War and Interregnum, financial and economic developments, political developments, development of Royal Navy, changes in bureaucracy and administration, scientific revolution and enlightenment; successes and failures in achieving imperial aims.
The nature of colonial rule	Models of political, social and economic exploitation and development and their success/failure e.g. privateering, mercantilism, trading/chartered companies, monopoly, cash crops, plantation, indentured labour, Navigation Acts, slavery, farming, banking, speculation, religion, ports, bases and trading posts, free trade; the relationship between Crown, Parliament and colonies: treaties and alliances with local rulers, peoples and tribes; taxation; law-making.
The impact of Empire on Britain and its emerging colonies	For Britain: political, socio-cultural and economic effects, including banking, speculation, population change, scientific and geographical knowledge, resources, products such as spices, sugar and tobacco, Royal Navy, personal and political prestige; for colonies: taxation, trade, economic developments, population change, political structures and internal power relationships, Native Americans, slavery, development of opposition and reasons for it e.g. American colonies, Jamaican Maroons, Mughals in India.

The British Empire and European Relations	The consequences of European alliances and rivalries on imperial developments and the impact of imperial developments on these alliances and rivalries, including with Spain, Portugal, France and the Netherlands; imperial causes of, and consequences for empire of wars, including the Anglo-Spanish Wars, the Anglo-Dutch Wars, Seven Years War, Wars of Spanish and Austrian Succession, War of American Independence; importance of ports, bases and trading posts.
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Depth Studies	Content Learners should be aware of debates surrounding the issues outlined for each in-depth topic:
Elizabethan Privateers 1558–1603	Nature and extent of privateering in the Elizabethan era and relationship between privateering and imperial development; motives, methods, extent of success and impact of key individuals (including Drake and Raleigh); economic, political, military and personal consequences of privateering; attitudes and ambitions of Elizabeth, Court and Parliament as regards colonial development and privateering; importance of the actions of privateers in relations with foreign powers and impact on European relations, including with Spain.
Britain and its American colonies 1660–1713	Attitudes of Crown and Parliament towards American colonies and impact of developments in Britain (Restoration, Glorious Revolution, religious tension over James II) on American colonies; form of rule and relationship between colonies and Britain; economic developments e.g. Navigation Acts; causes, nature and consequences of colonial rebellions during this period; impact of European wars on American colonies; importance of colonies in European power relations.
Clive and the East India Company: India c.1730–1773	Attitude and ambitions of the British Crown and Parliament towards India; military successes and failures and reasons for these; character, motives, actions and importance of Robert Clive; extent of success in achieving British aims in India at this time; economic developments; political developments; relations with foreign powers including France, the Dutch, the Mughal Empire; consequences of Company rule for India.